

The Pocket PC examined



PHOTOGRAPH: Jiten Gandhi, IMAGING: Ram

A close look at the Pocket PC, the tools it offers, and where it's headed

A complete mobile computing experience. Sounds weird to you? Not really. Just stop a while to consider how each generation of handheld has improved, how each new release is capable of doing much more than was possible earlier. And you will realise that handhelds are closing the gap in the race with desktop PCs fast—at least in terms of functionality.

Microsoft is no newbie when it comes to handhelds. Earlier devices powered by the Windows CE platform weren't exactly avant-garde. In fact, their presence on the market hardly left an impression. With the third version of the CE software, now called Pocket PC, Microsoft is hoping that it will be luckier the third time round. Looking back at the previous avatars of Pocket PC, this one is certainly attractive. But is a Pocket PC everything we want it to be in computing and gadgetry?

What does the Pocket PC offer?

If you're looking for a direct replica of your desktop's entire application suite, then the Pocket PC is not for you. It doesn't offer all the functionalities, not yet. But if you're looking for a core of neat utilities, Pocket PC is a platform that holds its own. It sums up the most useful tools for the mobile user, and then gives you some more. It boasts of tasks ranging from basic Internet applications and multimedia to managing spreadsheets and documents.

The word's out

You can use Pocket Word to access and edit MS Word documents on your handheld and make changes using the stylus as a writing tool, or by simply tapping the onscreen keyboard. Several advanced features such as macro support and Thesaurus have been left out, but it does have some of the key features of MS Word—the spell checker and the ability to use RTF files. Unlike Palm's memo pad, which is its primary means of entering short text-based information, Pocket Word allows for the formatting of documents.

Pocket Excel

As its name suggests, Pocket Excel is a scaled-down flavour of Microsoft's popular spreadsheet application. Considering that its purpose is to offer mobile finance calculation, you would expect Pocket Excel to do well despite being stripped of its powerful features. Unfortunately, with the Pocket PC's small screen size, you can view only a limited amount of data at a time and you are forced to keep scrolling through the pages to get at the bigger picture. However, one useful feature that the Pocket version carries is the tabs located at the bottom of the screen that let you toggle between multiple spreadsheets.

Just browsing through

Internet Explorer on the Pocket PC is an application, which acts as a clear separator between the Pocket PC and Palm platforms.